



THE TASTING GUIDE

Discovering the Green Gold of Your Adopted Tree

Presented by Adopt Your Olive

THE QUICK START: Quick Tasting Guide (For those in a hurry!)

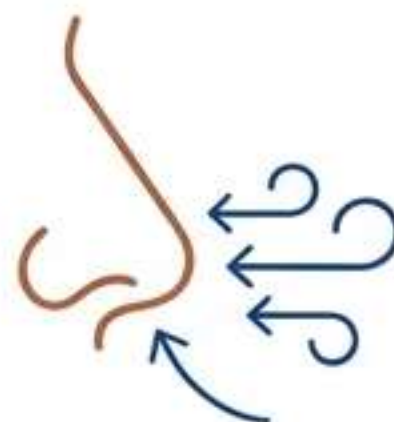
Can't wait to open the bottle? Here are the 4 fundamental steps to taste your extra virgin olive oil like a professional, in less than 3 minutes. The chapters that follow will explain the 'why' behind each one—but if you're in a rush, read just this page and you're ready.



1. Prepare (No distractions)

Pour a spoonful of your oil into a small glass (like an espresso cup or a cognac snifter). Cover it with one hand and, with the other, warm the bottom of the glass.

The heat of your hands will bring the oil to the perfect temperature (about 28°C) to release all the aromas.



2. Smell (In small bursts)

Remove the hand acting as a lid, bring your nose close, and take 3 or 4 short and fast inhalations. Do not take a long breath, otherwise, your nose will get used to it immediately.

Look for the 'Fruity': do you smell freshly cut grass? Almond? Artichoke?



3. Taste (Make noise without shame!)

Take a small sip. Don't swallow it right away! Move it over your tongue, then slightly part your lips and... draw in air through clenched teeth. Make noise, literally!

This technique is called Strippaggio and serves to vaporize the oil in your mouth so you can taste every single note.



4. Evaluate (The cough is a prize)

If it tingles in your throat and makes you cough: BINGO! 🏆 It is the sign that the oil is incredibly fresh and packed with polyphenols (the powerful natural antioxidants). Pungency is the greatest virtue of new oil.

If you taste a bitter flavor on the sides of your tongue: Excellent! It means your olives were harvested at the perfect moment.

If your supermarket oil does none of this: Now you know you were eating old, oxidized oil. Welcome to the world of true Extra Virgin!



The Fruit of Your Tree

Welcome to the world of true Extra Virgin Olive Oil.

If you are reading this guide, it means you have made an extraordinary choice: you have adopted an olive tree in Puglia with Adopt Your Olive and now you hold its green gold in your hands.

Forget the oil you are used to buying hastily at the supermarket. What you are about to taste is a living product, cold-extracted from healthy olives and processed in record time.

In this guide, we will teach you the secrets of professional tasters (Panel Testers). You will learn a fun and foolproof method to discover every nuance of your Puglian oil, and above all, you will learn how to defend yourself from commercial frauds.

Grab your bottle. The journey begins.



The Fatal Mistake: Tasting Oil Like Wine

We often think we know how to taste a product of excellence, but almost all of us make a fatal mistake: we taste the oil as if it were wine. Nothing could be more wrong! Oil and wine are two entirely opposite worlds:



WINE

Oxygen: Wine improves if you let it “breathe” and swirl it in the glass.

Color: The color of wine is fundamental to understanding its age and structure.

Temperature: Wine is tasted chilled or at room temperature.



EXTRA VIRGIN OLIVE OIL

Oxygen: For oil, oxygen is enemy number one (it makes it age faster!).

Color: In oil, color counts for absolutely nothing (brilliant green is not synonymous with quality, as we will explain shortly).

Temperature: Oil needs the heat of your hands to “open up.”



San
Severo



Your Oil, Its Story

Your olive tree grows in San Severo, in northern Puglia.

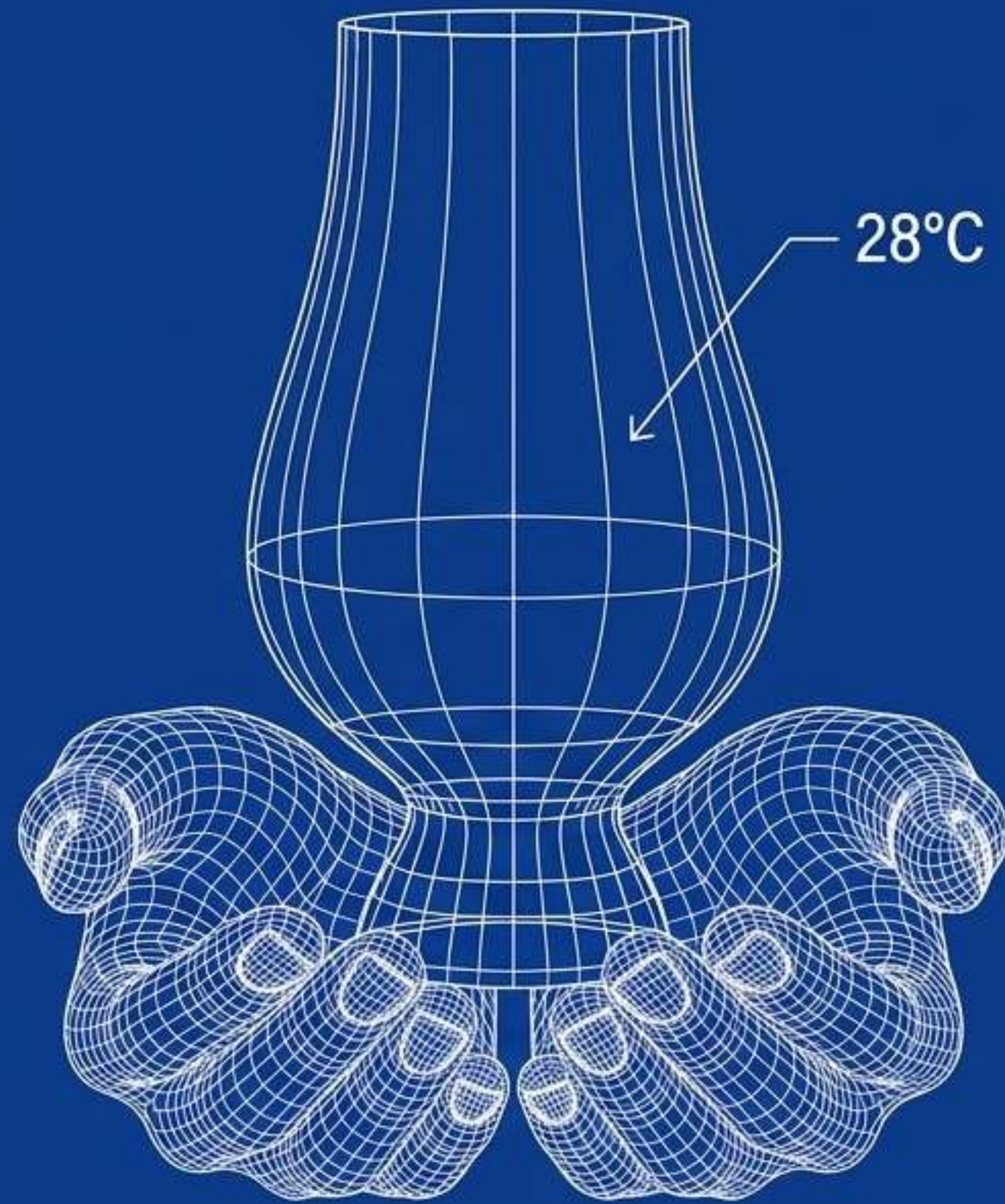
Its olives are called Peranzana — a variety so deeply rooted in this corner of Italy that it is difficult to find it elsewhere.

It is an olive with a straight spine: its oil is neither delicate nor neutral. It tingles, it is slightly bitter, it tastes of artichoke and freshly cut grass.

Exactly the things that, in the following chapters, you will learn to look for — and to appreciate.

🔪 Chapter 1: The Ritual of Preparation

Perfect tasting begins before you even open the bottle. You will not need laboratory equipment, but only a few small precautions to put your senses in the condition to work at their best.



The secret of the Blue Glass

If you have ever seen an official tasting, you will have noticed that experts use strange tulip-shaped glasses made of dark blue glass. Why blue? Simple: to hide the color of the oil! Our brain is programmed to trick us: if we see a neon green oil, we instinctively think "Wow, how fresh!". In reality, color depends only on the olive variety and the moment of harvest, not on quality.

How to do it at home

Use a small goblet (like a brandy snifter) or an espresso cup. The slightly narrowed shape toward the top will help funnel the aromas toward your nose.



Your hands: the perfect thermal tool

Extra virgin olive oil gives its best at about 28°C. At this temperature, the aromatic molecules “evaporate,” ready to be captured by your sense of smell. Never use flames or microwaves!

You already have the perfect method: pour about 10-15 ml of oil into the glass (a little more than a tablespoon). Cover the opening with the palm of one hand (so the aromas don't escape) and use the other hand to wrap around the bottom of the glass, warming it gently for 1 or 2 minutes.



Clean the “canvas”

To appreciate the colors of a painting, you need a blank canvas. For oil, you need a clean palate. Before tasting, drink a little room-temperature water. If you want to do things like a true pro, eat a small slice of green apple: the acidity of the apple is perfect for “resetting” your taste buds. Make sure you haven't drunk coffee or smoked in the last half hour, or you will miss most of the show.

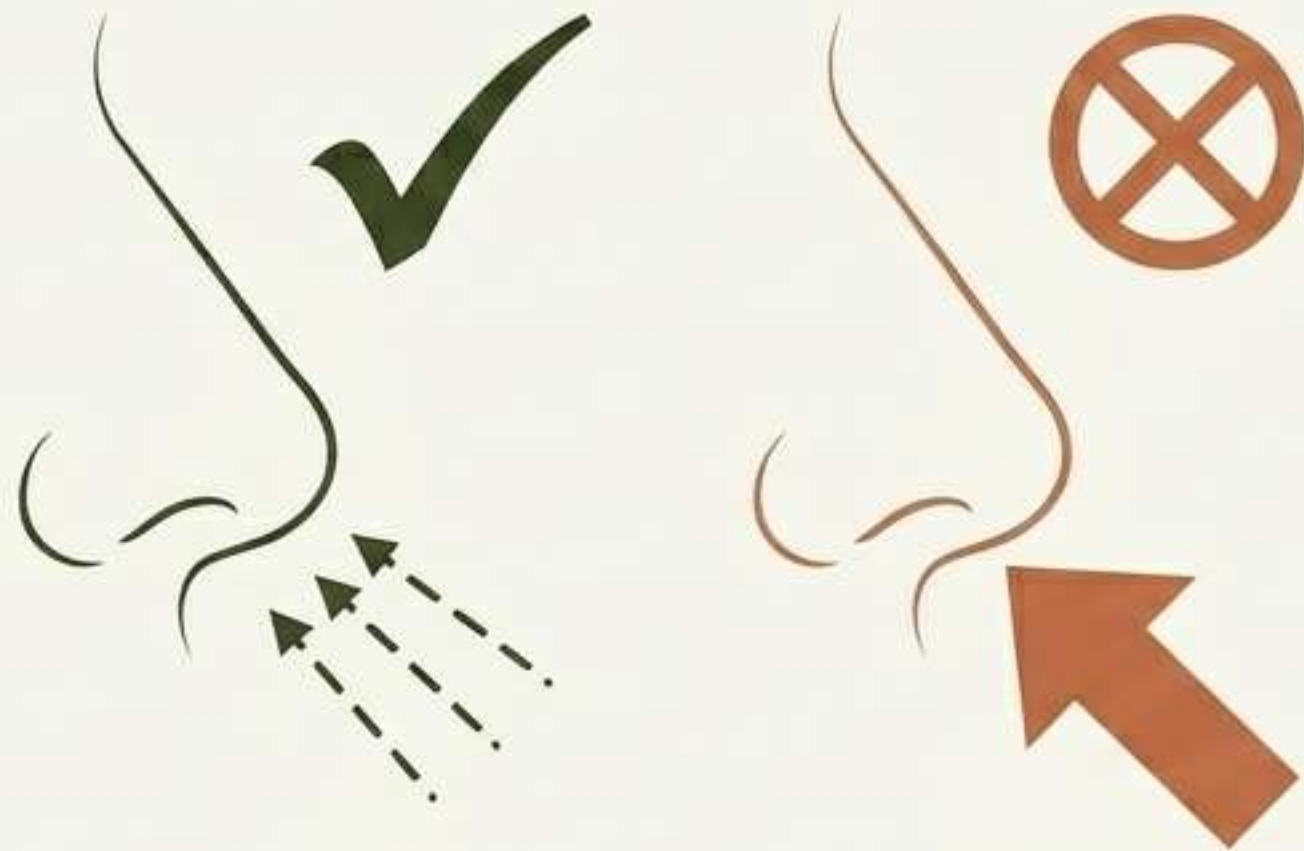
All set? Your oil is warm, the palate is clean. In the next chapter, we move into action.

🔪 Chapter 2: Olfactory Analysis

Awakening the Nose

Did you know that much of what we call 'taste' is actually smell? Your nose is the most powerful tool you have to evaluate an extra virgin olive oil. It is time to use it. You have warmed your glass, keeping it covered with your hand for a couple of minutes. The oil is now at about 28°C and the aromatic molecules are dancing, ready to be discovered.

The technique of the perfect sniff : Remove your hand from the glass, bring your nose close and... stop. Do not take a deep breath! If you inhale too much air all at once, your nose will saturate immediately and you will stop smelling the aromas after two seconds. The secret of tasters is to take 3 or 4 short, fast, and light inhalations. As if you were smelling a delicate flower. Pause for a few seconds, move the glass away, breathe normally, and then try again.



The Right Way

The Wrong Way

The Perfect Sniff

In Search of the 'Fruity' (Il Fruttato)

The first thing you must ask yourself is: does it taste of fresh olive? This primary aroma is called Fruity. If an oil does not have the fruity attribute, by law it could not even be called Extra Virgin! The oil from your Puglian tree will give you an explosion of fresh aromas. Close your eyes – and try to fish into your memories. Puglian oil often offers two great families of aromas:



Green Aromas

Reminiscent of freshly cut grass, tomato leaf, raw artichoke, or green almond. They are the sign of early-harvested olives, incredibly fresh and full of energy.



Ripe Aromas

Reminiscent of sweet almond, apple, or a slight floral hint. They indicate olives harvested at perfect ripeness, for a rounder oil.

There are no wrong answers! Do not worry if you smell 'green apple' and the person next to you smells 'almond.' Smell is intimately linked to our memory (which is why a scent can remind us of childhood). It is not an exam: relax, explore the notes of your oil, and have fun discovering what it reminds you of.

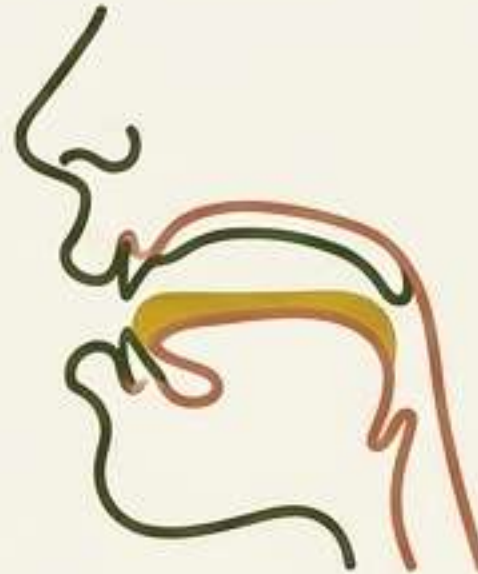
STRIPPAGGIO

It is the moment of truth. Now the oil enters your mouth, but forget how you taste wine or water. To truly understand the green gold, you must learn a magic word: Strippaggio (Slurping). In official panel tests, tasting rooms are full of people making very strange noises. It is a necessary and fun step.



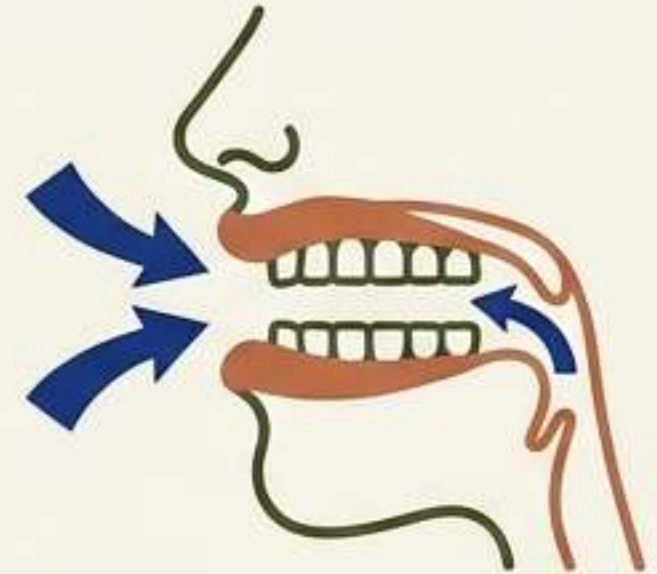
1. Sip

Take a small sip of oil (a teaspoon is enough).



2. Move

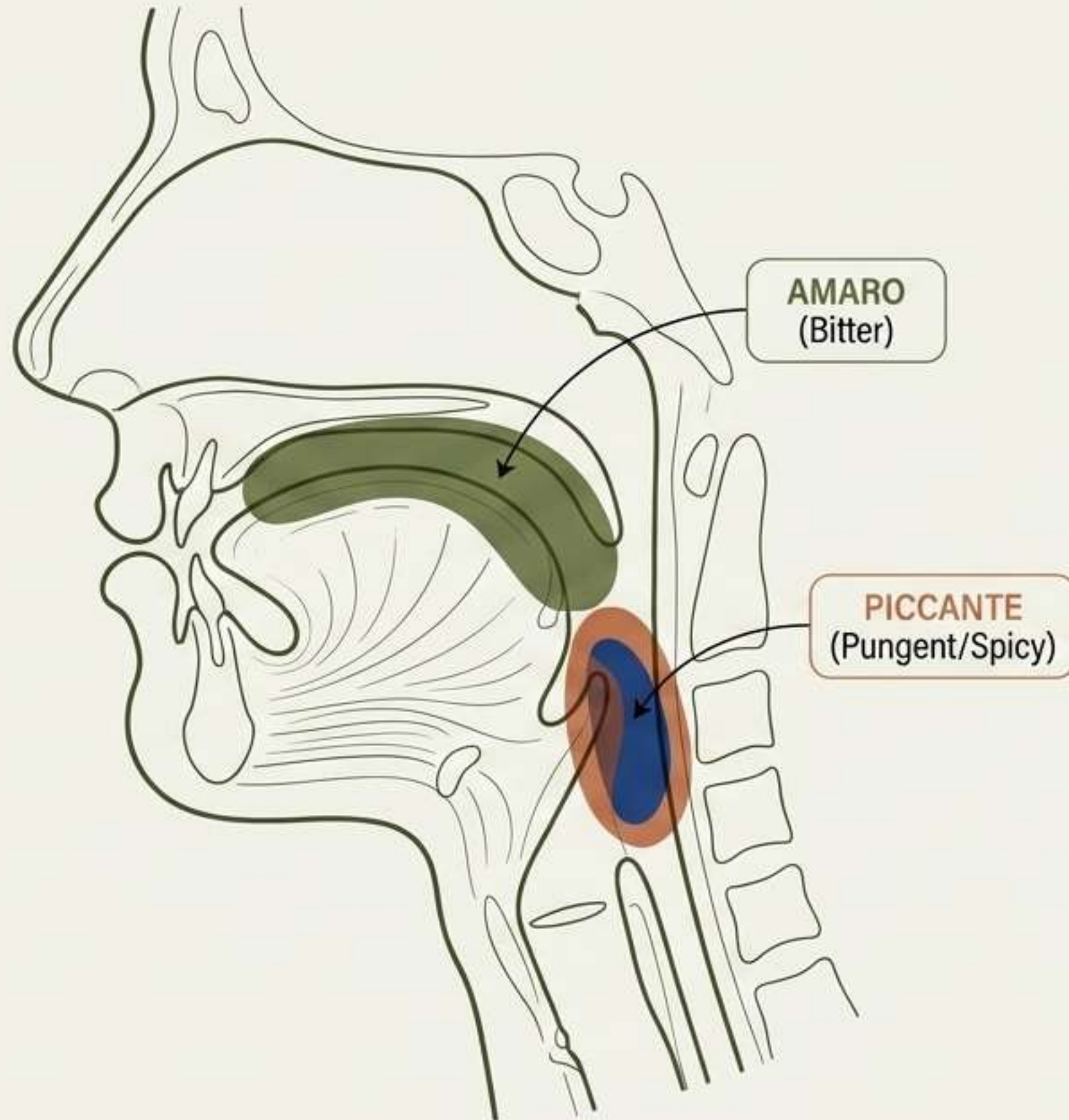
Do not swallow it! Gently move your tongue to distribute it over your entire palate.



3. Inhale

Slightly part your lips, clench your teeth, and draw air inward forcefully, 2 or 3 times.

Yes, you must make a noise similar to a slurp. By aspirating air through the oil in your mouth, you will vaporize it. In this way, the aromatic particles will rise into the back of your nose (retronasal route), and the flavor will literally explode on your palate.



The Two Kings of Quality: Bitter and Pungent

There is a gigantic false myth to dispel: "If the oil tingles, it is acidic." **FALSE!** The acidity of oil is a chemical parameter that the human palate cannot absolutely perceive. What you feel, instead, is the sign of maximum excellence.

The Bitter (on the tongue):

If you taste a bitter note on the sides and back of your tongue (reminiscent of artichoke or arugula), celebrate. It is the signal that your olives were perfectly healthy and that the oil is rich in **Oleuropein**, a powerful natural antioxidant.

The Pungent (in the throat):

That delicious tingling sensation you feel going down your throat is thanks to **Oleocanthal**. It is an extraordinary polyphenol that acts as a natural anti-inflammatory (scientifically, it has the same effects as ibuprofen!).

The cough is a prize! If you get a slight cough after swallowing, do not be alarmed. Among experts, the best oil is often defined as a "two-cough oil". It indicates that the product is incredibly fresh, just pressed, alive, and is giving you an injection of pure health.

(Note: As months pass, your oil will naturally soften, losing some of that spicy kick and becoming 'sweeter' and rounder. It is the beautiful life cycle of a 100% genuine product).

Chapter 4: Recognizing Defects (How to defend yourself)

Now that you know how to recognize the virtues (fruity, bitter, and pungent), it is time to learn how to defend yourself. Unfortunately, the market is full of oils labeled as “Extra Virgin” that actually hide objective defects.

The Golden Rule: A defect is always unpleasant, while an intense “style” may not please everyone but is always clean and fresh. (If an oil tastes of artichoke or tingles in the throat, it is a style. If an oil has a closed or unpleasant odor, it has a defect).

Public Enemy Number One: Rancid

It is the absolute most common defect, caused by oxidation (old oil, poorly stored, or exposed to light and heat).
The problem? Many people have gotten used to this flavor and confuse it with a “delicate” oil!



On the nose

A rancid oil does not smell of grass or nature. It smells of old dried fruit, stale walnuts, enclosed hay, or even cardboard.



In the mouth

It is completely flat. It does not tingle, it is not bitter, but it leaves an unpleasant “greasy” and fatty sensation on the palate that does not go away.

Other Common Defects

Fortunately, you will never find these in your freshly pressed Puglian oil, but you should know them to protect yourself in the wild:



Heated / Fusty (Riscaldo)

Smells of cooked or boiled olives. This is due to processing temperatures that are too high.



Musty / Muddy Sediment (Muffa / Morchia)

Smells of a damp cellar. This is typical of olives picked from the ground or poorly stored before pressing.

The Ultimate Takeaway: Remember: an oil of true quality always leaves your mouth clean and a persistent sensation of freshness.



Chapter 5: Storage (Treat it well, it deserves it)

You hold a living oil in your hands. And like everything alive, it can be ruined if treated with superficiality. The good news is that storing it well requires no special equipment. Three simple rules:



1. Away from light.

No windowsill, no shelf near the window, no bottle beautifully displayed on the counter. Light drastically accelerates oxidation.

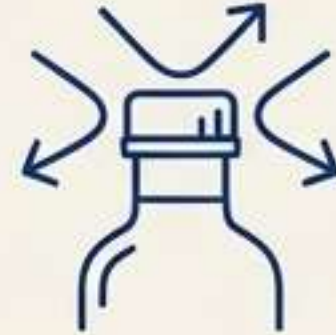
The best place is a closed cabinet. If the bottle is dark, you already have half the work done.



2. Away from heat.

The hottest place in your kitchen is "near the stove" — exactly where almost everyone keeps their oil. Move it.

The ideal temperature is between 14°C and 18°C. Not the refrigerator (which solidifies the oil), but a cool, stable place.



3. Capped, always.

Every time you leave the cap open, oxygen enters and does its silent work. Open, pour, close. That is it.

How long does it last?

Consume it within 12-18 months of harvest. Do not wait for it to run out: an oil used often lasts better than one opened and forgotten in the pantry. The best weapon against oxidation is to consume it.

Chapter 6: The 'Ultimate Test' (*La Prova del Nove*)

There is no better way to learn than by direct comparison. We challenge you to a fun test at home with friends or family.



1. Prepare the ring:

Take two identical small glasses. In one, pour a spoonful of your Adopt Your Olive oil. In the other, pour a spoonful of the commercial oil you currently have in your pantry.



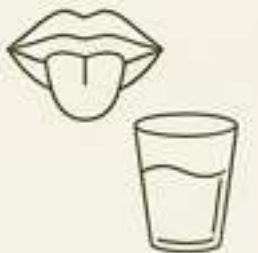
2. The Nose Test:

Warm both glasses with your hands. Smell the commercial oil first, then yours. The contrast will be striking. On one side, a flat, perhaps stale odor; on the other, a blast of fresh grass, nature, and freshly picked olives.



3. The Slurp Test:

Taste the commercial oil. It will likely slip away without a trace, or leave a greasy film. Clean your palate with water. Now taste your Puglian oil, drawing in air through clenched teeth.



Feel the **explosion** of flavor? The bitterness on your tongue and the tingle in your throat? **Congratulations!** You have just learned to recognize the difference between an industrial condiment fat and a true fresh, living 'fruit juice' packed with health. The product of your tree.



Chapter 7: Brief Guide to Pairings



Extra Virgin Olive Oil is not just a condiment; it is a true ingredient capable of revolutionizing (for the better) a dish. The secret to perfect pairing is playing by harmony.

**Early
Months**



Your New Oil (Intense and Pungent)

In its early months of life, your oil has a proud and rebellious character. Use it raw to give an extra gear to structured dishes. It is absolute perfection on a simple bruschetta rubbed with garlic, on a hot legume soup, on grilled red meats, or on bitter greens like chicory and turnip tops.

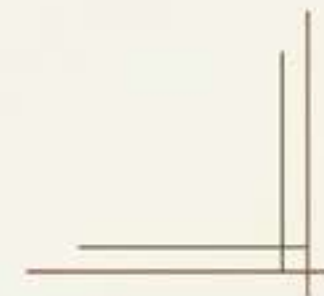


**Later
Months**



When the Oil Matures (Medium and Delicate)

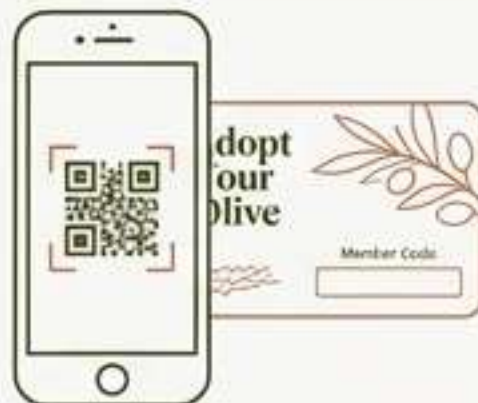
As months pass, the pungency will softly fade, leaving room for softer, rounder notes. In this phase, it becomes the perfect companion for baked or steamed fish, delicate salads, fresh cheeses, or even for preparing desserts and cakes instead of butter!



Conclusion: Much More Than a Condiment

We have reached the end of this journey. You now possess the tools to truly understand what is in your glass. You have discovered that behind a drizzle of oil is a universe of aromas, living nature, and careful choices. But the most beautiful thing is that this oil is the fruit of your tree in Puglia. It is the result of your adoption and your support for authentic agriculture.

What now? Organize your first tasting at home, do the 'Ultimate Test' with friends, and enjoy their faces when they discover the difference.



Know someone who deserves their own olive tree?

If the test convinced your friends, frame the QR code on the back of your Club Card. Use your member code to gift an adoption: they will find an extra surprise in their kit — and you will find one in yours at your next renewal!

Snap a photo of your Welcome Kit or your first tasting and tag us (@AdoptYourOlive). We can't wait to see your 'coughs' of happiness! Welcome to the family, and happy tasting.

